

A PLOTBREW WRITING WORKBOOK

THE ROMANTASY WORLDBUILDING WORKBOOK



Build worlds worth falling in love in.

What This Is

This is a worldbuilding workbook designed specifically for romantasy — fantasy romance where the world isn't just backdrop, but an active force shaping and pressuring the love story.

In romantasy, worldbuilding isn't separate from romance. The political marriage that forces enemies together, the magical bond that connects two people against their will, the ancient feud that makes love forbidden, the class divide that seems impossible to cross — these aren't setting details. They're the engine of your story.

This workbook helps you build worlds that create romantic tension by design.

Who This Is For

This workbook is for writers who want to:

- Build fantasy worlds that feel real and internally consistent
- Create external obstacles that pressure and test relationships
- Understand how geography, politics, magic, culture, and history can generate romantic conflict
- Move beyond generic fantasy settings to worlds that could only produce *your* story
- Develop worldbuilding that readers will want to live in

Whether you're writing your first romantasy or your tenth, whether you're a plotter who needs everything mapped before drafting or a pantsier who discovers your world as you go — this workbook meets you where you are.

How This Workbook Is Structured

Each section follows a two-part structure:

Part One: The Foundation

This is the worldbuilding itself — how your geography, magic, government, religion, economy, culture, or history actually works. These elements exist in your world regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Strong foundations make your world feel real. Readers can tell when a world has depth versus when it's cardboard scenery hastily assembled behind the love story.

Part Two: [Topic] & Romance

This is where worldbuilding becomes romantic tension. Each section shows you how to mine its topic for obstacles, intimacy, stakes, and conflict specific to love stories.

A magic system isn't just about what spells exist — it's about what happens when one character is vastly more powerful than the other, or when a magical bond forces intimacy neither chose, or when using power for someone you love costs something real.

REMEMBER

You need both parts. A romance between a servant and a prince needs a believable class system (foundation) that actually creates stakes and obstacles for their relationship (romance application). Skip the foundation and your world feels thin. Skip the romance application and you're not using your world to its full potential.

How to Use This Workbook

You Don't Have to Do Everything

This workbook is comprehensive — intentionally so. Not every section will apply to your story. Not every question will be relevant.

Skip freely. If your story doesn't involve inter-species romance, skip that section. If religion isn't a factor, move past it. If your characters aren't part of an institution, those questions aren't for you.

The goal isn't to fill every blank. The goal is to build what your specific story needs.

You Don't Have to Go in Order

The sections are numbered for reference, not because you must complete them sequentially.

Some writers start with magic because that's the heart of their world. Others start with the political situation that creates their central conflict. Some build geography first because place shapes everything else.

Start wherever you have the most energy or the clearest vision. Let that section inform the others.

Focus on What Creates Stakes

As you work through each section, keep asking: **How does this create obstacles for my characters?**

Not every piece of worldbuilding needs to directly pressure the romance — some details just make the world feel real. But if you find yourself developing elaborate systems that never touch your love story, you might be worldbuilding for worldbuilding's sake rather than story's sake.

The best romantasy worldbuilding does double duty: it makes the world feel real *and* it makes the romance feel impossible (until it isn't).

Use the Integration Checks

At the end of each section, you'll find Integration Checks — questions that connect that section's topic to others. These are important.

Worlds feel real when their systems interact. A magic system affects government (who has power). Religion shapes culture (what's taboo). History explains current politics (why the feud exists). Geography determines economy (who controls resources).

If each section exists in isolation, your world will feel like a collection of unrelated details. Integration Checks help you weave everything together.

Examples Are Guides, Not Rules

Throughout this workbook, you'll find examples drawn from popular romantasy novels — ACOTAR, Fourth Wing, From Blood and Ash, Serpent & Dove, and others. These show what good answers look like and what level of specificity is useful.

But these examples aren't templates to copy. Your world should be *yours*. Use the examples to understand the kind of thinking these questions invite, then develop answers that serve your unique story.

A Note on Tropes

Romantasy is a trope-heavy genre, and that's not a weakness — it's a feature. Readers come to romantasy *wanting* enemies-to-lovers, forced proximity, forbidden love, fated mates, morally grey love interests, and "there's only one bed."

This workbook doesn't shy away from tropes. Instead, it helps you execute them well.

The difference between a tired trope and a beloved one isn't the trope itself — it's the execution. An enemies-to-lovers romance where the enmity is shallow and easily overcome is boring. An enemies-to-lovers romance where both characters have genuine, legitimate reasons to hate each other — where choosing love means betraying everything they believed — that's compelling.

CORE PRINCIPLE

■ *Worldbuilding is how you make tropes feel earned.*

The forced proximity isn't just "they're stuck together" — it's the specific institution, geography, political situation, or magical bond that makes escape impossible.

The forbidden love isn't just "they're not supposed to be together" — it's the specific laws, cultural taboos, religious strictures, or historical enmity that makes their love dangerous.

Build your world to support your tropes, and your tropes will sing.

Before You Begin

You don't need to know your whole story before starting. Many writers discover their plots through worldbuilding — realizing that the magic system they developed creates a perfect obstacle, or that the political situation they built suggests an ending they hadn't considered.

Let the worldbuilding work *with* your story, not as a separate task you complete before writing.

And remember: worldbuilding exists to serve the story. A beautifully detailed world that doesn't create stakes for your characters is just a setting guide. A sparse world that perfectly pressures your romance is doing its job.

Build what you need. Skip what you don't. Make a world worth falling in love in.

The Sections

SECTION	TOPIC	WHAT IT COVERS
1	Geography & Environment	Physical world, climate, travel, how place creates obstacles
2	Flora, Fauna & Ecosystems	Plants, animals, bonded creatures, inter-species romance
3	Culture, Customs & Daily Life	Social norms, taboos, courtship, what's forbidden
4	Economy, Labor & Resources	Wealth, class, debt, what money means for love
5	Government, Power & Law	Politics, law, forbidden relationships, enemies-to-lovers
6	Religion, Myth & Prophecy	Faith, vows, divine purpose, what the gods demand
7	History & Lore	The past that haunts the present, inherited conflict
8	Magic System	How magic works, magical bonds, power dynamics

Additional Sections (9–21) cover specialized topics: technology, time & calendar, language, magic conflicts, pressure cooker settings, institutions, and more.

Appendix A: Revealing Worldbuilding in Prose — A practical guide to deploying your worldbuilding in scenes without info-dumps.

Let's Begin

Turn to whichever section calls to you first. There's no wrong starting point.

Your world is waiting to be built.

SECTION ONE

GEOGRAPHY & ENVIRONMENT

Geography isn't just a map — it's the landscape that shapes everything else. Mountains create borders that become political divisions. Deserts isolate cultures. Rivers determine where cities grow. Control of fertile valleys determines who holds power.

In This Section

Concepts & Frameworks

- How to Think About Geography
- Common Geographic Patterns
- Common Mistakes
- Reference: Travel Times

Part One: The Foundation

- The Big Picture: World's Scale
- Terrain Types
- Resources & Territorial Control
- The Sensory World
- Climate, Weather & Seasons
- Dangerous Regions
- Borders & Boundaries

Part Two: Geography & Romance

- Home & Belonging
- Entering Each Other's Worlds
- Travel & Distance
- Isolated Locations
- Geography as Emotional Landscape
- Integration Check
- Quick Reference

This section is divided into two parts:

Part One: The Foundation — The physical reality of your world. Terrain, climate, resources, dangers, and how geography shapes where and how people live. This is the geographic baseline that exists regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Part Two: Geography & Romance — How physical geography creates romantic tension. Separation and proximity, dangerous journeys together, entering each other's worlds, places that hold emotional meaning.

You need both.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. **Skip what doesn't fit.**

Worldbuild for its own sake if you want. A richly developed world has value beyond what appears on the page. Use the "romance connection" prompts for brainstorming if they're helpful, or leave them blank if that element is just background texture.

Come back later. If you're not sure whether something matters yet, skip it and return once your story has taken more shape.

This workbook is a tool, not a test.

How to Think About Geography in Romantasy

Geography in romantasy functions as a **pressure system** — the physical world can compress your characters together, force them apart, or create conditions where they must rely on each other. Before you draw a map, ask yourself: *What geographic situation does my romance need?*

Not every hill and river needs to serve the plot. But the geography you emphasize — the locations where scenes happen, the terrain your characters traverse, the distances between them — should be doing something. Background geography creates atmosphere and believability. Foreground geography creates story.

THE GEOGRAPHY-AS-FRICTION FRAMEWORK

Develop geography that creates friction — between your characters, or between what they want and what they can have.

Separation Friction What physical obstacles keep them apart?

- Different kingdoms separated by mountains
- An ocean that takes months to cross
- A magical barrier that can only be crossed under certain conditions
- War zones that make travel deadly

Proximity Friction What forces them together despite themselves?

- A snowed-in mountain pass
- A ship voyage with no escape
- An isolated estate or academy
- A dangerous journey requiring partnership

Resource Friction What geographic scarcity creates conflict?

- Water rights in a desert region
- The only pass through the mountains
- A rare magical resource found in contested territory
- Trade routes that require cooperation between enemies

Geography that doesn't create friction isn't wasted — it's just setting.

THE "PRESSURE COOKER" PRINCIPLE

The most effective romantasy settings function as pressure cookers — environments that trap characters together and force interaction. When characters can't escape each other, they're forced to confront conflict instead of avoiding it, rely on each other despite distrust, and share space long enough for attraction to build beneath their defenses.

The key is that *leaving must be impossible, dangerous, or carry unacceptable consequences*. When characters can't escape each other, they're forced to confront

conflict instead of avoiding it, rely on each other despite distrust, and share space long enough for attraction to build beneath their defenses.

Think about what makes the container seal tight:

- **Physical trapping:** Islands, academies, sieges, ships, remote estates — locations with literal boundaries characters cannot cross
- **Circumstantial trapping:** Dangerous wilderness requiring partnership, diplomatic missions, shared exile — situations where separating means failure or death
- **Environmental trapping:** Storms, seasons, magical barriers that prevent departure — external forces that make leaving impossible regardless of desire
- **Social/political trapping:** Arranged marriages, hostage situations, court obligations — circumstances where leaving would destroy reputation, alliance, or lives

The pressure cooker works because proximity breeds intimacy. Characters see each other at their worst. They can't maintain facades. Small moments accumulate — shared meals, overheard conversations, accidental touches in tight quarters. The setting does half the work of bringing them together.

The Key Question: If your characters could simply walk away from each other, would they? If yes, your geography might need to make walking away impossible, dangerous, or costly.

Common Geographic Patterns in Romantasy

Settings That Force Proximity

SETTING TYPE	WHY IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The Academy/Training Ground	Characters live, train, and compete in close quarters with no escape	<i>Fourth Wing, Zodiac Academy</i>

SETTING TYPE	WHY IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The Isolated Estate	Limited cast, limited space, limited options for avoidance	Gothic romances, <i>Pride and Prejudice</i> variations
The Ship/Caravan	Moving container with enforced proximity and shared danger	Pirate romance, trade caravan stories
The Siege/War Camp	External threat forces cooperation; death is the alternative	Military romantasy
The Prison/Captivity	Hostage and captor, shared cell, or trapped in enemy territory together	Captive romance, enemies-to-lovers
The Dangerous Quest	Mission requires partnership; separating means failure or death	Quest narratives, escort missions
The Snowed-In/ Stranded	Weather or disaster traps characters until conditions change	Cabin romance, "only one bed"
The Royal Court	Political obligations, arranged proximity, can't leave without scandal	Court intrigue, political marriage

Geographic Barriers That Create Stakes

BARRIER TYPE	ROMANTIC FUNCTION	STORY POSSIBILITIES
Mountain ranges	Separate nations/ cultures; make travel seasonal	Characters from opposite sides; winter trapping
Oceans	Create complete separation; make departure permanent	Letters across distance; the weight of leaving
Deserts	Isolate cultures; make resources precious	Oasis politics; survival journeys
Magical borders	Can be crossed only by certain people or under certain conditions	One character can cross, one cannot
War zones	Make travel deadly; create no-man's-land between peoples	Enemies from opposing sides
Political borders	Crossing means treason or exile	Forbidden love across enemy lines
Cursed/Blighted lands	Regions too dangerous to cross; require special protection	Must find another way; one character immune, one isn't
Class geography	Slums vs. palace district; social ruin to cross	Wrong-side-of-tracks romance; secret meetings in between spaces

Environmental Conditions That Affect Romance

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Harsh winters	Traps characters indoors; requires shared warmth	Forced proximity; "snowed in" scenarios
Dangerous nights	Characters must shelter together after dark	Shared watch; protective sleeping arrangements
Seasonal access	Passes close, ships can't sail, travel becomes impossible	Racing against time; trapped until spring
Resource scarcity	Sharing becomes necessary; generosity becomes meaningful	Sharing food/water; sacrifice for the other
Extreme heat	Travel only possible at night; requires shade-sharing, water rationing	Night travel intimacy; sharing precious water; heat exhaustion care
Hostile territory after dark	Monsters or predators hunt at night; must camp together for safety	One bed/bedroll situations; taking turns on watch; protective instincts
Corrupted/poisoned land	Regions that drain magic or health; must move quickly or rely on healer	Dependency on one character's abilities; racing against deterioration

Common Mistakes with Geographic Worldbuilding

Mistake #1: The Teleporting World

Characters travel vast distances with no sense of time passing. A journey that should take weeks happens between chapters with no mention of how they traveled or what dangers they faced. Distance has no weight. Separation has no stakes. Reunion carries no emotional punch.

FIX

Establish travel times and stick to them. The journey itself can be where the romance happens.

Mistake #2: The Convenient Geography

Geographic features appear or disappear based on plot needs. A mountain range exists when you need to separate characters but vanishes when they need to reunite. Readers notice. Stakes that feel fake are stakes that don't matter.

FIX

Establish your geography early and let it constrain you. Let the physical world create problems you didn't plan for — those problems often generate the best scenes.

Mistake #3: The Empty Map

You have a map with named places, but none feel lived-in. The geography exists but doesn't affect anything. Geography should create culture, which creates characters, which creates conflict. If your geography doesn't explain why people are the way they are, your world is just a painted backdrop.

FIX

For every major geographic feature, ask: *How does this shape the people who live here?* Let geography explain cultural difference.

Mistake #4: The Consequence-Free Environment

Your world has dangerous regions and deadly terrain — but no one suffers consequences from them. Characters trek through the Deadly Wastes and emerge fine. If danger is all threat and no delivery, readers stop believing in it. And if readers don't believe the world is dangerous, they don't believe your characters need each other to survive it.

FIX

Let the environment actually hurt people. Show consequences — exhaustion, injury, loss. Make survival meaningful.

Mistake #5: Geography Without Emotional Resonance

You describe the setting in detail, but it's all physical — mountains are tall, forests are dense, cities are crowded. None of it connects to how your characters feel. Setting should be emotional landscape. The place where they first met should feel different than other places. The character's homeland should feel like *home*.

FIX

Give each major location an emotional quality, and let characters experience it differently. The same castle might feel like prison to one character and sanctuary to another.

Reference: Place Name Patterns

Good place names make your world feel real. You don't need to invent a whole language — just notice how real places get their names.

Most names come from geography (Blackwood, Riverside), historical figures (Washington), or descriptions in old languages (Oxford means “ford where oxen cross”). Borrow the patterns, not the exact words.

How to Research Naming Conventions

Want to create place names that evoke a particular culture or aesthetic? Here's how to find patterns yourself:

Quick Research Methods

- **Search “[language] place name meanings”** — e.g., “Old Norse place name meanings” or “Welsh place name elements”
- **Search “[language] words for [terrain]”** — e.g., “Japanese words for mountain” or “Gaelic words for river”
- **Look up real places** — Search “etymology of [real place name]” to see how actual names were constructed
- **Wikipedia's toponymy pages** — Search “[language] toponymy” for organized lists of place name elements
- **Behind the Name** — The website behindthename.com has a place names section with etymologies

For deeper language work, see *Section 11: Language & Communication*.

Common English Place Name Patterns

Mix prefixes and suffixes to generate names. “Ash” + “ford” = Ashford. “Black” + “moor” = Blackmoor.

PREFIX / SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Ash-	ash tree	Ashford, Ashby
Black-	dark, black	Blackmoor, Blackpool
Brad- / Broad-	broad, wide	Bradford, Broadstairs
Glen- / Green-	valley / green	Glendale, Greenfield
King- / Bishop-	royal / church estate	Kingston, Bishopstoke
New- / Old-	new / old	Newcastle, Oldham
Stone- / Stan-	stone, rocky	Stoneham, Stamford
Whit- / White-	white	Whitby, Whitfield
-ham	homestead, village	Nottingham
-ton / -town	fenced settlement	Brighton
-ford	river crossing	Oxford
-ley / -leigh	clearing, meadow	Barnsley
-burgh / -bury	fortified place	Edinburgh
-moor / -mere	marshland, lake	Windermere
-holme / -holm	island, water meadow	Stockholm

Nordic/Scandinavian Place Name Patterns

Good for cold, northern, Viking-inspired settings. Old Norse roots appear in many English place names too.

PREFIX / SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Stor- / Stór-	great, large	Storfjord, Stóravatn
Ny- / Nýr-	new	Nykøbing, Nýdalur
Holm-	small island	Holmsland, Stockholm
Nor- / Norð-	north	Norðfjörður, Norway
Suð- / Sör-	south	Suðureyri, Sörmland
Stein-	stone, rock	Steinkjer, Steinberg
Kvit- / Hvít-	white	Kvitfjell, Hvítá
Svar- / Svart-	black, dark	Svartskog, Svartengren
-by	farm, settlement	Whitby, Grimsby
-vik / -wick	bay, inlet	Reykjavik, Lerwick
-fjord / -firth	long narrow inlet	Sognefjord
-heim / -hem	home, world	Trondheim
-berg / -borg	mountain / fortress	Gothenburg
-ness / -nes	headland, promontory	Skagen
-land	land, territory	Iceland, Gotland

Celtic/Welsh Place Name Patterns

Good for mystical, ancient, fae-adjacent settings. Celtic names often describe landscape features poetically.

PREFIX / SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Aber-	river mouth	Aberdeen, Aberystwyth
Caer- / Car-	fort, stronghold	Caernarfon, Cardiff
Llan-	church, sacred enclosure	Llandudno
Pen-	head, top, end	Penrith, Penzance
Tre- / Tref-	homestead, town	Tremaine
Dun- / Din-	hill fort	Edinburgh (Dun Edin)
Bal- / Bally-	homestead, settlement	Balmoral, Ballymena
Kil- / Cil-	church, monk's cell	Killarney, Kilmarnock
Ben- / Beinn-	mountain, peak	Ben Nevis, Ben More
Bryn-	hill, mound	Brynmawr, Brynteg
Drum- / Druim-	ridge	Drummond, Dromore
Strath-	wide river valley	Strathclyde
Glyn- / Glen-	valley	Glencoe
Loch- / Lough-	lake	Lochaber
Inver- / Innis-	river mouth / island	Inverness

Slavic Place Name Patterns

Good for Eastern European-inspired settings. Slavic names often use descriptive compounds.

PREFIX / SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-grad / -gorod	city, fortified place	Belgrade, Novgorod
-ov / -ova / -ovo	belonging to (possessive)	Sarajevo, Krakow
Novo- / Novy-	new	Novosibirsk
Staro- / Stary-	old	Starograd
-pol / -pole	field	Sevastopol
Belo- / Byelo-	white	Belgrade (Beograd)
Cerno- / Chern-	black	Chernobyl
Krasno-	beautiful / red	Krasnodar, Krasnoyarsk
Zlato- / Zlaty-	golden	Zlatograd, Zlatoust
Pod-	under, at the foot of	Podgorica, Podolsk
Za-	beyond, behind	Zagreb, Zaporizhzhia
Gora- / Hora-	mountain, hill	Jelenia Góra, Bilogora
Brod-	ford, river crossing	Slavonski Brod, Brody
Veliko- / Veliky-	great, large	Veliky Novgorod
-sk / -sko	place/region suffix	Gdansk, Minsk

Reference: Travel Times (Fantasy Approximations)

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Walking (easy terrain)	15-20 miles	Healthy adult, good weather
Walking (difficult terrain)	8-12 miles	Mountains, forest, desert
Horseback (sustainable)	25-35 miles	Without exhausting the horse
Horseback (hard riding)	50-60 miles	Cannot maintain long-term
Ship (sailing)	100-150 miles	Dependent on wind and current
Carriage/wagon	20-30 miles	Roads required; slower on rough terrain

Your World's Place Name Patterns

Create prefixes and suffixes that fit your world's languages. What sounds right for this culture?

PREFIX/SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE IN YOUR WORLD
<i>Kel- / -kel</i>	<i>silver, moonlight</i>	<i>Kelvareth (Silver City)</i>

Part One — The Foundation

The Big Picture: Your World's Scale

What's the geographic scope of your story?

Describe the geographic scope of your story and the primary locations where your romance takes place.

Example: Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy) — Thornwick Academy, a remote magical school on sea cliffs where students are trapped together for the term.

YOUR ANSWER

*If your world is large, where specifically does your romance happen?
You don't need to detail everything — just locations that matter.*

LOCATION TYPE	NAME/DESCRIPTION
Primary location	<i>The Winter Court — an ice palace where protagonist is held hostage, forced into proximity with the prince</i>
Primary location	
Secondary location	
Secondary location	

Kingdoms & Nations Overview

Got multiple kingdoms or nations in your world? This table helps you keep track of them.

You don't need to fill in every field. Just jot down what you know right now. Perhaps you only know the name and climate — that's fine. You can always come back later as your story takes shape.

This is reference material. Fill in what you know now; come back as your world develops.

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 1	KINGDOM/NATION 2
Name		
Capital		
Neighbouring lands		
Known for		
Main industry/resource		
Climate		

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 1	KINGDOM/NATION 2
Primary species		
Religion		
Government type		
Allies		
Enemies/rivals		
Notable landmark		
Role in your story		

Terrain Types

Not every terrain needs equal development. Consider what exists in your world — *mountains, forests, deserts, plains, wetlands, coastlines, islands, rivers, tundra, magical or unusual terrain* — then focus on the 2-3 that actually matter for your story: the ones your characters traverse, fight over, or call home.

Only fill in terrains that matter. If your characters never see a desert, skip it.

What terrains shape your story?

TERRAIN	WHERE?	WHAT IT PROVIDES	WHAT CHALLENGES IT CREATES
<i>Mountains</i>	<i>Northern border between kingdoms</i>	<i>Natural defense, mineral deposits, isolation for monasteries</i>	<i>Impassable in winter, separates lovers from different kingdoms, treacherous passes</i>

Resources & Territorial Control

Geography determines who has what — and therefore, who has power. Fertile land, fresh water, mineral deposits, trade routes: these are worth fighting over, worth marrying for, worth dying for.

In romantasy, resource control can create power imbalances that drive conflict between our two (or more) love interests. Resource control is a believable tactic to explain arranged marriages, political alliances, or economic pressures that force characters to **make impossible choices**.

How to write it: Don't explain resource conflict through exposition — show it through what characters can and can't do. A character from a water-scarce region might flinch at seeing someone leave a bath running. Someone from contested territory notices strategic value in landscape others see as beautiful. Let resource awareness emerge through small reactions, casual comments about price or scarcity, and the background hum of what everyone in this world worries about. When two characters come from opposite sides of a resource conflict, show the tension through what they assume about each other, what they're careful not to say, and the moments when privilege becomes visible.

Reference: Natural Resource Ideas

Use this list for inspiration when filling out the table below.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Precious Metals	Gold, silver, copper, iron ore, bronze, platinum, mithril
Gems & Stones	Diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, pearls, amber, jade, obsidian, marble
Textiles	Silk, wool, linen, cotton, rare furs, leather, spider-silk, feathers
Food & Agriculture	Grain, rice, olives, wine/grapes, sugar, honey, salt, spices, rare fruits
Animal Products	Ivory, bone, whale oil, animal fat, beeswax, dyes from shells, ambergris
Plant Products	Timber, herbs, medicinal plants, rare flowers, resins, incense, tea, coffee
Fuel & Energy	Coal, oil, charcoal, peat, magical crystals, dragon-fire, captured lightning
Magical Resources	Ley line access, enchanted springs, magical creatures, spell components
Curiosities	Fossils, adder stones, meteoric iron, ancient artifacts, bottled starlight

What natural resources are geographically concentrated?

Think beyond the obvious. What does this world have that ours doesn't? What scarcity shapes daily life?

RESOURCE	WHERE IT'S FOUND	WHO CONTROLS IT
<i>Fertile farmland</i>	<i>River valley between the two kingdoms</i>	<i>Contested — marriage alliance proposed to end the conflict</i>
Fertile farmland		
Fresh water		
Timber/forests		
Mineral deposits		
Coastal access/ports		
Mountain passes		

RESOURCE	WHERE IT'S FOUND	WHO CONTROLS IT
Magical resources		

What geographic resource creates tension or conflict in your world?

Water rights? Arable land? Trade routes? Does the conflict show up as war, political marriage, trade embargo, or something subtler?

YOUR ANSWER

How does geographic resource control affect your characters?

Does one character's family/nation control something the other's needs? Is there territorial dispute between their peoples?

YOUR ANSWER

Continue in Section 4

You've mapped where resources are found and who controls them. In Section 4: Resources & Scarcity, you'll explore how resource control creates economic stakes, cultural traditions, and romantic tension.

The Sensory World

Geography isn't just about what's there — it's about what it feels like to be there. The sensory details of your setting create the emotional texture of scenes. A first kiss hits differently in a garden heavy with night-blooming jasmine than in a stone corridor that smells of torch smoke.

How to write it: Filter sensory details through your POV character's emotional state. A character falling in love notices the warmth of sunlight, the sweet smell of blossoms, the softness of grass. The same garden, to a grieving character, might feel too bright, the flowers cloying, the birdsong intrusive. You don't need to describe everything — pick 2-3 sensory details per scene that reinforce the mood you're creating.

Avoid the "weather report" opening (starting scenes with neutral descriptions of setting). Instead, integrate sensory details into action and emotion: not "The room was cold" but "She pulled her cloak tighter, breath misting in the unheated chamber." The character's interaction with the environment reveals both setting and feeling simultaneously.

What does your primary setting look, sound, smell, and feel like?

Close your eyes and walk through this place. What hits your senses first? What would your protagonist notice?

SENSE	DESCRIPTION
What you see	
What you hear	
What you smell	
What the air feels like (temperature, humidity, wind)	

How does the environment change at different times of day?

Dawn meetings feel different than midnight ones. What time of day would be most romantic here? Most dangerous?

TIME	DESCRIPTION
Morning	
Midday	
Evening	
Night	

What's beautiful about this place?

The details a character falling in love would notice. What would make someone homesick for this place?

YOUR ANSWER

What's harsh or uncomfortable about this place?

What do people endure or complain about? What takes getting used to?

YOUR ANSWER

Climate, Weather & Seasons

Weather creates immediate physical conditions that affect what's possible — travel, agriculture, warfare, daily life. Seasons can function as deadlines (they must marry before winter closes the pass), as waiting periods (trapped together until spring thaw), or as markers of time passing in a slow-burn romance.

How to write it: Use seasonal markers to show time passing without stating it directly — the first frost, the smell of rain after months of drought, the angle of afternoon light. Weather works best when it creates immediate physical problems: wet clothing that must be removed, cold that requires shared warmth, heat that makes tempers short. Don't just describe weather — show characters adapting to it, complaining about it, making decisions around it. A change in season can mirror emotional shifts: a relationship that thaws as winter ends, tension that builds with summer heat, a reckoning that arrives with autumn.

What's the overall climate?

Tropical, temperate, arid, polar? How does it shape what people wear, build, and grow?

YOUR ANSWER

What seasons exist and how distinct are they?

Traditional four seasons? A long winter and brief summer? Magical seasons tied to something other than the sun?

YOUR ANSWER

What season is your story set in?

Seasons create mood and constraint. What does this season make possible for your romance? What does it prevent?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Season	
What this season makes possible	
What this season makes impossible	

How do seasons affect life in your world?

When can armies march? When do ships sail? When are weddings held? When must everyone stay indoors?

SEASON	WHAT'S POSSIBLE	WHAT'S IMPOSSIBLE
Summer/warm season		
Winter/cold season		
Transitional seasons		

Does the season create pressure or opportunity in your story?

Racing against winter? Waiting for spring thaw? Only able to travel in summer?

YOUR ANSWER

Dangerous Regions

Every world has places that are deadly — and therefore avoided, or crossed only with preparation and company. Dangerous regions serve romance by raising stakes and forcing partnership.

What regions are dangerous or forbidden?

Every world has places people warn you not to go. What makes them deadly? What would force your characters there anyway?

REGION	WHAT MAKES IT DANGEROUS	WHO GOES THERE ANYWAY (AND WHY)
<i>The Blighted Wastes</i>	<i>Corrupted magic, monsters, no water for miles, disorienting mists</i>	<i>Exiles, desperate smugglers, and our protagonists who must cross it to reach sanctuary</i>

Do your characters travel through dangerous territory?

Shared danger bonds people fast. What threats would force them to rely on each other?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Where and why	
What dangers they face	

Borders & Boundaries

What geographic features create borders?

Mountain ranges? Rivers? Oceans? Magical barriers? Deserts?

YOUR ANSWER

How permeable are these borders?

Easy to cross? Heavily guarded? Physically impassable? Seasonally accessible?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters come from opposite sides of a significant border?

Borders create “us” and “them.” What assumptions would each character have about someone from the other side?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What separates them	
What crossing means (legally, socially, personally)	

Part Two — Geography & Romance

Home & Belonging

Geography isn't just physical — it's emotional. Home is one of the most emotionally charged concepts in romance. Characters may leave home to find love, may be torn between love and home, may find that home becomes wherever the other person is — or may discover that choosing this person means exile from everything familiar.

How to write it: Show home through specific, sensory details rather than telling readers a place matters. What does your character reach for when they're homesick? What smell instantly transports them back? When writing scenes set in a character's home territory, let them move through space with ease and familiarity — they know which floorboard creaks, which window sticks. Contrast this with how they move through unfamiliar spaces: hesitant, observant, slightly off-balance. The tension between "where I belong" and "where love is taking me" creates some of romance's most powerful emotional beats.

Where does your protagonist feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they feel most themselves:

YOUR ANSWER

What does home look, smell, sound like to them?

The sensory details that mean “home”:

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your love interest feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they’re most themselves. How different is it from your protagonist’s home?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does each character feel like an outsider?

Fish-out-of-water moments reveal character. Where would each feel uncertain, uncomfortable, or judged?

CHARACTER	WHERE THEY FEEL ALIEN
Protagonist	
Love interest	

Entering Each Other's Worlds

If your characters come from different places, visiting each other's territory is significant. There's a particular vulnerability in bringing someone into your home territory. You see your world through their eyes, noticing things you'd stopped seeing — both the beauty and the flaws.

How to write it: When a character enters their love interest's world, filter every observation through their outsider perspective. What confuses them? What impresses them? What makes them uncomfortable? Use their reactions to reveal both the world and the character. The "native" character, meanwhile, experiences a different kind of vulnerability — suddenly aware of poverty they'd normalized, privilege they'd taken for granted, or customs that seem strange when explained aloud. Write the small moments: the love interest automatically reaching to help with something the visitor doesn't know how to do, the visitor mispronouncing a word everyone here knows, the native defending their home against a criticism they privately agree with. These fish-out-of-water scenes build intimacy because they require explanation, patience, and the trust to look foolish in front of someone.

Does one character visit the other's home territory?

Bringing someone home is an act of vulnerability. What would they be proud to show? What would they rather hide?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who visits whose world	

What's the sensory experience of entering unfamiliar territory?

What do they notice first? What's strange? What's beautiful? What's uncomfortable?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the "native" character see their home differently through the visitor's eyes?

Pride? Shame? New appreciation? Defensiveness?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the visitor understand about their partner after seeing where they come from?

Place explains people. What becomes clear about your love interest once you see where they grew up?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel & Distance

Distance creates stakes. If characters can teleport anywhere, separation has no weight.

If journeys take weeks, every departure matters.

How to write it: The journey is not filler between plot points — it's where relationships transform. Travel strips away social roles and forces characters into shared vulnerability: sleeping near each other, seeing each other tired and irritable, depending on each other for survival or navigation. Use the physical demands of travel to create intimacy: one character tending another's blisters, sharing body heat in cold camps, the enforced proximity of a small boat or narrow trail. Write the rhythm of travel — the silence that becomes comfortable, the conversations that only happen when there's nothing else to do, the way danger bonds people faster than safety ever could. When writing separation across distance, make the weight felt through what characters can't do: letters that arrive too late, news that travels slowly, the agony of not knowing. A reunion after real distance hits harder than one after a brief absence.

How do people typically travel?

On foot? Horseback? Ships? Flying creatures? Magical transportation?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel Time Reference

These are real-world estimates. Feel free to adjust for your world.

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Walking (comfortable pace)	15–20 miles / 25–32 km	Healthy adult with breaks
Forced march	25–30 miles / 40–50 km	Exhausting, not sustainable
Riding (sustainable)	25–35 miles / 40–55 km	One horse, regular rest
Hard ride	40–50 miles / 65–80 km	Tiring the horse
Changing horses (relay)	80–100 miles / 130–160 km	Fresh mounts at stations
Sailing ship (favorable wind)	100–150 miles / 160–240 km	Highly variable
Carriage/wagon	20–30 miles / 32–50 km	Roads required

How long does travel take between key locations?

Distance creates stakes. A week apart feels different than a year. How painful is separation in your world?

ROUTE	TRAVEL TIME
From capital to border	
From one character's home to the other's	
Across the dangerous region	

Do your characters undertake a significant journey?

The road is where walls come down. What would a long journey together reveal about each of them?

ASPECT	DETAILS
From where to where	
How long	
What happens during the journey	

Isolated Locations

Isolation is romance's secret weapon. When characters cannot leave, they cannot avoid each other — and avoidance is the enemy of romantic development. Isolated settings force confrontation, require cooperation, and create the pressure that transforms reluctant attraction into something undeniable.

How to write it: Establish early why leaving isn't an option, and make that reason feel real and insurmountable. Then use the confined space intentionally: the only warm room where everyone gathers, the narrow hallways where characters keep brushing past each other, the shared resources that require negotiation. Write the claustrophobia alongside the intimacy — isolation can feel oppressive, and characters might resent their forced proximity even as attraction builds. The best isolated-setting romances use the location's specific constraints: a ship means someone must keep watch, an academy means competitive dynamics, a snowed-in estate means dwindling supplies. Let the setting generate plot. And remember: when characters finally could leave but choose to stay, that choice becomes a declaration.

What isolated locations exist?

Islands, remote estates, mountain fortresses, ships at sea, academies, pocket dimensions:

LOCATION	TYPE	WHY PEOPLE GO	WHY LEAVING IS DIFFICULT
<i>Stormhold Keep</i>	<i>Remote mountain fortress</i>	<i>Political prisoners sent there; protagonist exiled after scandal</i>	<i>Mountain passes are snowed in 8 months/year; magic wards prevent unauthorized departure</i>

Geography as Emotional Landscape

The physical world can resonate with or contrast against the emotional journey. A love scene in a sunlit meadow feels different than one in a crumbling tower. A confession during a storm carries different weight than one in stillness.

How to write it: Match or intentionally contrast your setting with emotional beats. A first kiss in a dangerous place carries urgency; the same kiss in a peaceful garden suggests safety and choice. Use pathetic fallacy sparingly but effectively — a storm during a confrontation, sunlight breaking through as characters reconcile. More subtly, let characters notice their environment differently based on emotional state: a character in love sees beauty everywhere; a heartbroken character finds the same landscape bleak. Create “their place” — a location that becomes sacred to the relationship, whether it’s where they first met, first kissed, or survived something together. When characters return to meaningful locations, the resonance should be felt without being over-explained. A single line — “She hadn’t been back to the bridge since that night” — can carry enormous weight if you’ve built the association.

What’s the emotional quality of your primary setting?

Does it feel oppressive, expansive, peaceful, threatening, beautiful, decaying?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a location that becomes meaningful to your characters specifically?

A place they return to, a place where something changed, a place that’s “theirs”:

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
How does geography explain cultural differences? (Reference: Section 3)	
How does geography create or reinforce power structures? (Reference: Section 5)	
How does geography interact with magic? (Reference: Section 8)	
What geographic resource or territory is contested in your world?	

Quick Reference: Geographic Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
<i>Key location 1</i>	<i>The Winter Court — where protagonist is hostage and love interest is prince</i>
Key location 1	
Key location 2	
Key location 3	
The contested resource or territory	
The barrier separating peoples or characters	
The dangerous region	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The isolated location	
The significant journey (from → to)	
The place that matters emotionally	

Map Making (Optional)

You don't need a map. Plenty of great fantasy stories were written without one.

That said, maps can help you keep travel times consistent and visualize where things are in relation to each other. If you decide to make one, let your story's needs guide you.

For example: How far is the border your characters are fleeing toward? Is the palace defensible? Where might lovers meet in secret? Build your geography around the situations your plot requires.

Map-Making Tools

Free options unless noted. Search these names online for current links.

- **Inkarnate** — Popular fantasy map maker (free tier available)
- **Azgaar's Fantasy Map Generator** — Procedural generation with editing
- **Wonderdraft** — One-time purchase, professional quality
- **Donjon** — Random generators for maps and dungeons
- **World Anvil** — Worldbuilding wiki with map tools (subscription)

What to Include on Your Map

Consider which of these appear in your world. You don't need all of them.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE LOCATIONS
Geographic features	Mountains, rivers, forests, lakes, coastlines, islands, deserts, swamps, valleys
Political boundaries	Kingdom borders, disputed territories, neutral zones, conquered lands
Cities & settlements	Capitals, port cities, border towns, villages, abandoned settlements
Trade & travel	Major roads, trade routes, mountain passes, river crossings, ports
Fortifications	Castles, walls, watchtowers, military camps, fortresses
Religious sites	Temples, shrines, pilgrimage routes, sacred groves, forbidden places
Magical locations	Ley lines, magical academies, cursed regions, power sources
Story-specific	Where characters meet, where they're forbidden to go, where they flee to

Final Thought: Your map isn't just where things are — it's why characters must make the choices they make. The mountain range is why two nations distrust each other. The desert is why whoever controls the oasis controls the trade route. Build geography that explains your world and creates the situations your story needs.